

http://del.icio.us

Ever caught yourself wondering how many other people online are bookmarking a site you just tagged yourself? Well, now you can find out—and do more while you're at it

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You often find yourself bookmarking sites in your browser, but you can't really carry your stored favourites around with you all the time, can you? Actually, with <http://del.icio.us>, you can bookmark your sites online, which you can then access from anywhere, provided you have a PC and an Internet connection.

Navigation

At its simplest, like we said, the site is an online bookmarking tool. You have an individual page where you can tag a URL that you want to record or refer to. The page can be a bit confusing for a first-timer, and we recommend that you check out the Help link on the home page if you are altogether new to bookmarking. Much of what the site does has been explained here, and reading all this before you even register might save you a good deal of time. For example, under "Site Navigation," you will find a visual explanation of their navigation tool bar called "Breadcrumbs."

The bookmarking on del.icio.us is very similar to the bookmarking procedure you would follow with your browser. The advantage is that with del.icio.us, you don't have to restrict the number anymore. All your tags are visible on the right of the page in a cloud view. You can also bundle sites under a particular tag to create an open folder of sorts, so that similar pages are clubbed together. Besides, if you want to use two tags for a similar page, you can: a site on Afghanistan might classify as political as well as geographical, so you can tag this as "geographical + political".

It's Chow Time

So you've created your user profile and have started tagging sites. Here is the next important bit. For every Web site you've bookmarked, you see the total number of people who have also marked the site. Clicking on this statistic will take you to a page where you can see all those other users. From here, you can click on any user's name to check out the sites they have tagged, and

view their choices. If you like something they have, you can bookmark that for yourself. Or you can check out the people who have tagged the same sites as your *host user*, and you can further conduct a search. The interloping of pages and the path you take is continually visible courtesy a toolbar—the Breadcrumb, at the top.

Surfing possibilities at the site are huge. For beginners, your search starts when you discover a similar interest—in this case a Web site—with another user. From there on, you can search under particular tags and also keep a count of the number of bookmarks a site has received.

For example, if a site has been marked by 1,204 users, it's likely that you might like it too—given that you're a "typical" surfer, of course. Then, you can create a community of your own and even tag a bookmark for a friend. Also, any pages marked for you by friends will be stored in your profile page.

Here's Why...

While you can see some of the bookmarked sites on the home page, you can't bookmark them for yourself or create a page of your own until you register with the site.

You can subscribe to sites under a particular tag such as "economics," and every site with that tag is redirected to your Inbox. If you do not wish to receive sites from a particular tag or person, you can just retag them as "antisocial" in the



A click on the tag statistic shows other users on this page

settings, and they stop featuring on your page.

The site does not take for granted that you know how to use the page: it aids and guides you on how to go about tagging and using its features. There are also explanations for various tools and feeds such as RSS and HTML. To a seasoned user, these directions may look like kindergarten stuff, but it's pretty handy if you're new to a social bookmarking site—of which this is one of the most popular.

Navigating the site does need some getting used to. The site we profiled in this space last month—digg.com—is similar in terms of what you can achieve, but is easier to use. With del.icio.us, there's a little more work involved—it isn't easy to navigate right from the word Go. The initial couple of hours may be frustrating, but more and more use facilitates better understanding. At the end of a good four visits—assuming you spend at least thirty minutes in each visit—you'll find the site indispensable!

Del.icio.us is a welcome alternative to the other online social activities—namely, IM and blogging. Granted, you cannot establish contact with the other users or message them, but the blog on the site provides a way to interact with the del.icio.us community.

The site is still being developed, and even as we write this, it mentions changes they're planning to introduce.

If you want to combine utility with a bit of social hobnobbing, del.icio.us is the place to be. ■

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A Profiled page has bookmarked sites